FORTRESS SE-LA

THE RETURN OF BIJJI KAUL

Towards the end of October, the full extent of the disaster on the Nam Ka Chu was coming through to the country in bits and pieces. Details of the fiasco in which 7 Infantry Brigade of the Indian Army had disintegrated within three hours was stunning everyone. To make matters worse, apart from 2 Rajput, which had stood its ground even as it had been decimated, there was no news of Brigade HQ or the other three battalions at this stage. Some of the men who were not killed or captured by the Chinese would either freeze to death or die of severe frostbite and starvation while trying to escape to the plains of Assam via Bhutan.

In the Kameng Frontier Division, as we have seen, the Chinese tsunami had not been restricted to the Nam Ka Chu Valley; a second thrust along the Nyamjang Chu Valley had smashed past the scanty defences of 4 Division HQ. In the absence of any pre-planned withdrawal plan, the fallback had proved to be nothing but a headlong retreat. So much so that Tawang, built up as 4 Division's vital ground over the last three years, was abandoned in a matter of hours, the decision being taken even before the fighting at Bum-la had begun. The Eastern Army Commander, Lieutenant General Bogey Sen, who had refused to countenance pulling 7 Brigade back onto the forward slopes of Tsangdhar after Kaul had rushed back to Delhi with a realistic assessment of the situation after the 10 October incident, was present in Tawang on 22-23 October and though he was to sack Niranjan Prasad on grounds of cowardice a few hours later, he did nothing to countermand the order to evacuate Tawang.

With Kaul out of the equation on medical grounds, both Eastern Command and HQ IV Corps were championing the Thorat defensive line, wanting to pull the retreating troops back to Bomdila. However, as we know, the DMO at Army Headquarters, Palit, felt Se-la was a far better defensive option to stop the Chinese advance. Palit, who played a critical